

Taming Crocodiles

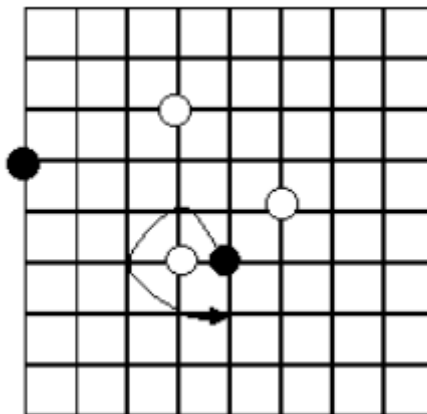
2002, Darik (Ilya) and Alyosha Popov, https://dariks.narod.ru/games_space.html

To play, you need an 8×8 grid and two pencils of different colors (or a pen and a pencil).

Rules. One player controls the **Crocodiles** (C), the other the **Tamers** (T). The playing field is a "cage" in which the opposing sides try to trap one another.

The Crocodiles move first and place a dot on any grid intersection (including one on the boundary wall). The second player then places a Tamer on any intersection.

During the second turn, another Crocodile and another Tamer appear on the board. On the third turn, a third Crocodile appears, and the Tamers begin to move.



after the five-ply setup and the first move

Movement paths run along the grid intersections. Paths may neither cross nor touch one another. It is allowed to touch the walls of the cage, but movement along a wall is not allowed.

On each turn, the Tamers must make a total movement of **four cells**. This movement may be performed by one Tamer alone or divided between both Tamers, but the total distance moved must equal four segments.

The Crocodiles move similarly, but they may—and must—make only **three segments of movement** per turn.

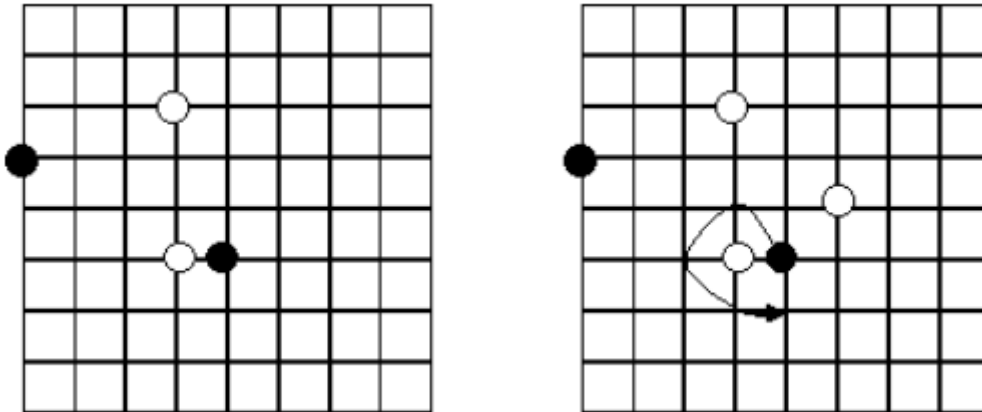
The player who is unable to complete a full move loses.

The game is very engaging because it lasts only a few moves, yet no winning strategy has ever been discovered. The Crocodiles and the Tamers have different capabilities, and it has not been determined which side has the better chances.

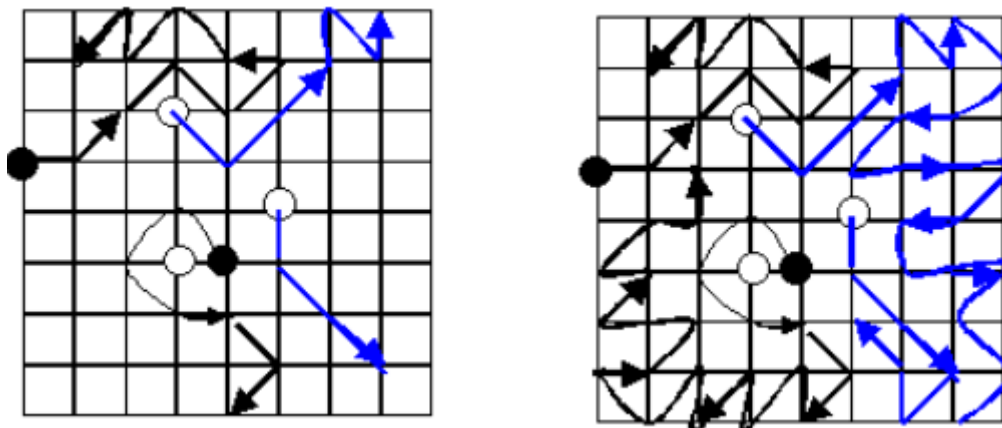
Let's see how the game continued:

Move 4. The Crocodiles started to wall off the right-hand side of the board, while the Tamers advanced both of their pieces, moving each of them two cells.

Move 5. The Crocodiles have now essentially cut off the right side of the board. The Tamers succeed in closing off the remaining sides of the enclosure.



Move 6. However, the Crocodiles are more enduring: since they are required to make fewer movement segments per turn, the territory available to them may be enough. From this point on, both sides try to use their remaining space as efficiently as possible.



Move 12 (the final move). The Tamers are to play. Although they can still make two movement segments in the center of the board, a legal turn requires four segments of movement. Since they cannot complete the required four, they lose the game.